



Gaming headsets

Gaming headsets are a very funny bunch. The ideal headset is a matter of grave debate among pro-gamers and audiophiles wouldn't be caught dead with one of them.

When we're talking about gaming headsets here, we're talking about sets that are meant for gamers; sets that provide a gamer with an enhanced toolset and actually advance his skillset as a gamer. For this reason we've completely ignored "true" 5.1 and other such surround sound headsets. They have their place, but they're better left in a class of their own.

We haven't really seen much innovation in this category and that's to be expected. A good headset, whether it's brand-spanking new or a decade old, will still sound good because the way we fundamentally experience sound hasn't evolved. You have diaphragms that move and create pressure waves that you perceive as sound via your ear, that's it. We have seen some really cool designs, especially those from ThermalTake and Razer, but when it comes to pure performance there can only be one winner.

What differentiates a gaming headset from that preferred by an average user or audiophile is the sound signature. While an audiophile set will need to be tonally accurate, a gaming headset is supposed to be very light on bass and especially capable of reproducing voices accurately. Basically, every sound that the game can produce must be heard by the gamer, the quality itself shouldn't matter as long as the gamer knows what's going on. It's a very fine line to walk and one that many manufacturers stumble on and end up making sets that are just plain bad rather than useful. Gaming headsets are not about outrageous colours and design, they're about audio quality, but a quality determined by a different set of benchmarks.

Zero1 winner SteelSeries Siberia V2

This set has impressed us from day one. There are many variations of this set, such as the Frost Blue, Diablo III edition and a Heat Orange edition, but all of these variations are just cosmetic upgrades and they're still based on the original V2's design and have the same aural characteristics. What makes these sets special is the way they handle audio from games. A gaming headset is supposed to reproduce all the aural feedback that a game is providing in the most accurate



◀ HEADPHONES – IN EARS:
STEELSERIES SIBERIA V2
Price: ₹11,890

way possible and if this means that atmosphere and thump has to be sacrificed, so be it. Other manufacturers have tried to do this, but few have succeeded in reproducing that feedback with a minimal loss in tonal quality the way these SteelSeries V2 based sets have. There is a distinct lack of bass, but it's not as bad as on some of the other sets that we've heard and the positioning is spot on. The headset is definitely on the more expensive side, but it's worth it if you are, or have aspirations of becoming, a pro-gamer.

Worthy mentions

ThermalTake Level 10M Diamond Black

This lovely red and black headset is easily among the best looking sets we've received at our test labs; the guys at BMW's Designworks have done a stellar job in creating this piece of art. That excellent design needs to be mated with excellent audio quality for the effort to be worthwhile and for the most part, ThermalTake has succeeded. The audio is very accurate, as accurate as the Siberia V2 in fact, but the bass is more severely reigned in than on any other set we've tested, completely ruining the ambience in many games. That said, this is supposed to be a professional set for pro-gamers and to that audience, it gives them exactly what they need. The only reason this set didn't win a Zero1 award is because the SteelSeries V2 was a more comfortable and had a better sound signature.



ThermalTake Level 10M Diamond Black

Price: ₹9,900

Logitech G230

As good as the Siberia V2 are, they're for a very niche audience and not everyone will want to spend money on them. For the more mainstream gamer, the Logitech G230 is the set we would recommend. The set is quite capable of positioning audio sources accurately in games and while it isn't as precise as the V2, the shortfall is compensated for by more enhanced bass that does offer a better overall experience than the V2. This set is a great all-rounder, and we recommend it to anyone in the market for a decent gaming headset. It does have an elder brother, the G430, a worthy contender in itself, but if you're going to spend that much on a set, you might as well get the SteelSeries V2.



Logitech G230

Price: ₹5,495